



“**SOVEREIGNTY IS THE ABSOLUTE AND PERPETUAL POWER OF A COMMONWEALTH... THE HIGHEST POWER OF COMMAND...**”

Jean Bodin, French political philosopher, 1576



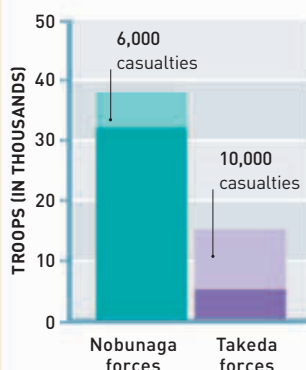
CATHERINE DE MEDICI
(1519–89)

The Italian-born Catherine married Henry II of France in 1533. On his death in 1559, she became monarch in all but name as France fell into turmoil, with her first two sons, Francis II and Charles IX, proving too young and inexperienced, and Henry III facing a deteriorating political situation. Her goal to preserve the Valois monarchy was a spectacular failure.

any case, the plot failed—Coligny, though wounded, survived—but the mood in Paris became explosive. Catherine may then have persuaded the king that a Huguenot takeover was in the offing and could be forestalled only by killing all the principal Huguenots in the city. Equally, the subsequent bloodletting may have been spontaneous. At all events, not only was Coligny murdered, but **more than 3,000 Huguenots were killed**. Across France, 20,000 may have died in the following weeks.

THE NORTH AFRICAN COAST of the western Mediterranean was a key focus of **Ottoman-Christian rivalry**, with Spain, in particular, seeking to prevent Muslim raids on its shipping. Yet, gradually, the handful of North African cities in Spanish hands were lost—Algiers in 1529, Tripoli in 1551, and Bugia in 1555. By 1574, only Tunis remained. Its final fall in August 1574 to an overwhelming Ottoman fleet marked the **end of Habsburg ambitions in North Africa**, which from now was to remain firmly within the Ottoman orbit.

The **Battle of Nagashino**, fought in June 1575 between the forces of **Takeda Katsuyori** (1546–82) and an alliance led by the warlord **Oda Nobunaga** (see 1560–62), marked a decisive moment in the evolution of warfare in Japan—the first effective use of firearms. The arquebus muskets introduced by



Battle of Nagashino

Nobunaga's men outnumbered the Takeda troops by more than 2:1, but it was Nobunaga's skillful use of firearms that won the day for them.



Selimiye Mosque

Built by Mimar Sinan for Selim II in Edirne and completed in 1575, this mosque is the supreme statement of Ottoman Islamic architecture.

the Portuguese in the 1540s had been eagerly imitated by the Japanese despite being very slow to load. Nobunaga's solution was to have three guns for each man firing them, supported by teams of loaders. The result was a near continuous fire against which the Takeda clan's conventional cavalry and infantry were helpless.

Spain's efforts to suppress the **Dutch Revolt** (see 1572–73) foundered in 1575. Unable to levy taxes in the Netherlands, Philip II could not pay his troops and they mutinied, looting and murdering indiscriminately. Philip's authority in the Netherlands disintegrated. The vacuum was filled by the Dutch themselves—Catholics and royalists as well as the rebellious Protestants. Their agreement was sealed by the **Pacification of Ghent**, signed in November 1576.



Hopelessly outnumbered, the Portuguese were in effect exterminated at the Battle of Alcácer Quibir. Portugal lost not only its king but most of its nobles.

JUST AS PHILIP II'S ATTEMPTS TO REASSERT HIS AUTHORITY over the heretical Netherlands were derailed by his simultaneous need to confront the Ottomans in the Mediterranean, so the Ottomans' attempts to confront the heretical Safavids in Persia were distracted by their conflicts with Spain. The pause in the conflict after the fall of Tunis in 1574, confirmed by a peace treaty in 1580, freed both states to pursue their goals elsewhere. The benefits for the **Ottomans** were immediate—a **string of conquests in Georgia and Azerbaijan** that, by the fall of Tabriz in 1585, saw both incorporated within their empire.

In August 1578, the king of Portugal, Sebastian, was killed at the **Battle of Alcácer Quibir** in northern Morocco. The battle had two consequences. One was to confirm **Ahmad al-Mansur** (1549–1603) as the new sultan of an Ottoman-backed **Morocco**. The other was a **succession crisis in Portugal**. Sebastian's heir was his 66-year-old great-uncle, Henry, a cardinal. He died, childless, 17 months later. Among the claimants to the throne was Philip II (see 1580).

After the Pacification of Ghent (see 1576), Philip II was forced to agree not just to pull out his troops but to restore traditional privileges across the provinces. But on the question of religion, he remained adamant—Catholicism must be restored everywhere. The violence flared again. Philip's envoy, Don Juan,

stormed the city of Namur; in retaliation, Calvinist dissenters established themselves in cities across the south. In January 1579, the Catholic nobility of the south reaffirmed their loyalty to Philip, forming the **Union of Arras**. The northern provinces formed the **Union of Utrecht**. To the miseries of the Netherlands were added the horrors of civil war.

Chichak helmet

The Ottoman rawhide helmet with copper gilt was so effective it was widely imitated in Europe in the 17th century.

